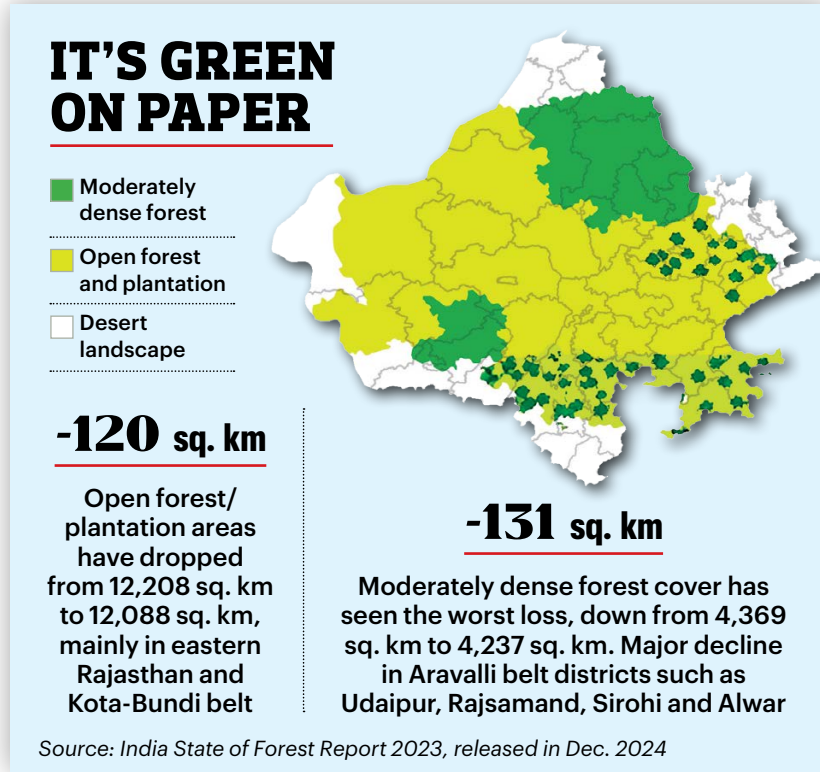
most no surviving saplings" from the original planting. Instead, officials saw hasty signs of replanting, near a newly built road.

In May 2025, a joint counting team corroborated that. The saplings they saw were "pencil-thin" and under two feet in height, with visible signs of recent JCB activity nearby. The tribunal diagnosis was blunt: a hasty cover-up.

On January 27, it pulled up Rajasthan's forest department, flagging possible financial irregularities, given the attempt to mask earlier failures ahead of inspections. The NGT central zone bench, Bhopal, has directed Rajasthan's principal chief conservator of forests to personally probe accountability and submit an action-taken report by March 16, with a fresh plantation plan for 400 ha. with strict survival monitoring.



THE PLANTATION PARADOX

The episode reopens a national question: why does India's green cover often improve on paper even as ecological quality declines palpably? Environmentalists warn that compensatory afforestation is increasingly a numbers game, one that puts a question mark on the credibility—and the success—of India's climate mitigation strategy.

Rajasthan offers a stark case study. Despite aggressive drives over years, the state's forest and tree cover remains among India's lowest. The India State of Forest Report shows that, between 2021 and 2023, Rajasthan's forest cover fell from 16,654.96 sq. km to 16,548.21 sq. km—from 4.87 to 4.84 per cent of its area. Moderately dense forest declined by 131.24 sq. km. Open forest fell by 120.56 sq. km. Gains were largely confined to scattered tree cover and canal-fed pockets. Or, of course, to plantation 'statistics' on paper. A sapling that dies within a year contributes almost nothing to long-term carbon sequestration. Yet in official accounting, plantation targets are often treated as proxies for climate mitigation success.

Field officers privately acknowledge the structural challenge. In arid districts, sapling survival often drops below 30-40 per cent without sustained watering, protection and species planning, steps rarely funded after the initial planting phase hullabaloo dies down. Often, planting is not done at all, money is pilfered; later, plantations are claimed to have 'died', a believable half-truth in a state where the Celsius crosses 50. The NGT cited another infirmity: nearly 2,375 ha. of new 'forests' were vulnerable to encroachment and grazing, hardly ideal for young plantations.

The NGT order comes at an awkward time for the Rajasthan government, which has been pushing mass plantation campaigns. Last year, school education minister Madan Dilawar promised survival audits for every sapling planted under the Centre's flagship greening push—an implicit admission that merely counting pits in plantation drives is no longer credible. Officials say the audit mechanism is still being operationalised. Kota shows why such verification cannot become another layer in what environmental economists call a dangerous illusion of progress. ■

Takeaways

- **Rs 25 crore earmarked for 2,375-hectare plantation, to compensate for forest lost to NH-27 widening 20 years ago**
- **NGT inspections find zero original sapling survival**
- **Signs of hasty replanting make NGT suspicious**
- **Environmentalists warn compensatory afforestations are often a ruse for corruption**